



Teacher Scenario Cards

Common moments, the framework lens, what to say — and the tool to reach for.

1 Shuts down, then blames you

Work gets hard → they go silent or say “you didn’t even explain it.”

WHAT’S LIKELY HAPPENING

Shame, dressed as blame. “I don’t get this” becomes “I’m dumb,” so they push it onto you. The shutdown is a freeze response — they’re out of their thinking window.

TRY THIS

Regulate before you reason. Lower your voice, get alongside them (not across from them), then shrink the task to one step.

SAY

“This part’s tricky. Let’s just do the first step together.”

REPAIR / NEXT STEP

“You’re not in trouble — your brain hit overwhelm. What’s the one part you’re stuck on?”

REACH FOR (in the app)

Quiet Space → “shut down” (the Stuck helper) · Harsh → Kind

2 Thoughts come out as “mean”

Blunt, sharp comments that land as rude — but aren’t aimed to wound.

WHAT’S LIKELY HAPPENING

Impact vs. intent. Their inner monitor isn’t catching thoughts before they leave their mouth. It’s a filter/impulse gap, not malice.

TRY THIS

Assume good intent out loud. Teach that some thoughts are “inside thoughts,” and give them a fast repair line they can reuse.

SAY

“I don’t think you meant that the way it landed. Want to try it again?”

REPAIR / NEXT STEP

“That came out sharper than I meant — what I meant was ____.”

REACH FOR (in the app)

Think It → Say It

3 “I’m so stupid” — harsh self-talk

Hits a mistake → turns it on themselves, hard and fast.

WHAT'S LIKELY HAPPENING

Identity collapse: a behavior (“I missed it”) becomes an identity (“I’m stupid”). The inner critic is loud, not true.

TRY THIS

Separate the deed from the self. Name it as the critic, then model the coach voice out loud.

SAY

“A hard moment isn’t who you are. Let’s hear the coach voice.”

REPAIR / NEXT STEP

Let them fill it in: “I made a mistake — that’s human. What can I learn?”

REACH FOR (in the app)

Harsh → Kind

4 About to blow — big feelings

Voice rising, body tight, right on the edge of a meltdown.

WHAT'S LIKELY HAPPENING

Dysregulation — out of the window of tolerance. No lesson lands here; the body has to settle first.

TRY THIS

Be the calm they borrow. Lower your voice, slow your own body, and breathe together before any words.

SAY

“I’m right here. Let’s breathe first — words after.”

REPAIR / NEXT STEP

Once settled: “That was a big wave. What helped it pass?”

REACH FOR (in the app)

Quiet Space (Right Now) · Co-Regulation · Breathing

5 Withdrawn — “I’m fine” (but isn’t)

Flat, quiet, an “I’m fine” that clearly isn’t.

WHAT'S LIKELY HAPPENING

Masking. Naming feelings is hard, and pressure makes it harder. Silence is information, not defiance.

TRY THIS

Low pressure. Offer options, not an interrogation — and a way to point instead of explain.

SAY

“You don’t have to talk. Want to point to how you feel?”

REPAIR / NEXT STEP

“I’m glad you showed me. We can just sit a minute.”

REACH FOR (in the app)

Beyond “Fine” · Feelings Wheel · Emotion Wheel

6 Hurt someone, won't take responsibility

Did something, denies or deflects, won't say sorry.

WHAT'S LIKELY HAPPENING

Shame blocks repair. If "I did a bad thing" means "I am bad," owning it feels unsurvivable. Forgiveness makes room to grow.

TRY THIS

Protect the identity so the behavior can be owned. Keep the repair small and concrete.

SAY

"You're a good kid who did a hard thing. What's one way to make it right?"

REPAIR / NEXT STEP

Name the impact, agree on one repair action — then let it be done.

REACH FOR (in the app)

Make It Right

7 Digs in — "my way or shutdown"

Gets redirected → shuts down and won't do the assigned work (calm, not defiant).

WHAT'S LIKELY HAPPENING

Often a skill gap, not a "won't." Starting can be a real barrier (weak task-initiation), and a demand — even a kind redirect — can land as lost control or sensory overload, tipping them into shutdown. For some it's trauma: control means safety. Reward charts stall because the reward is one more demand they still can't initiate.

TRY THIS

Scaffold the start — don't just reward the finish. Do the first step together, chunk it to one visible step, offer real choice in how and order, use declarative language, and regulate the body first.

SAY

"Hmm, this one looks tricky — I'm not even sure where I'd start. Want to pick which two we try?"

REPAIR / NEXT STEP

Treat the "no" as communication, not defiance. Teach a break/help card they can hand you instead of shutting down. Plan together at the start, and let them signal when they're ready.

REACH FOR (in the app)

Quiet Space (co-regulate + the Stuck step) · Beyond "Fine" (real choice)